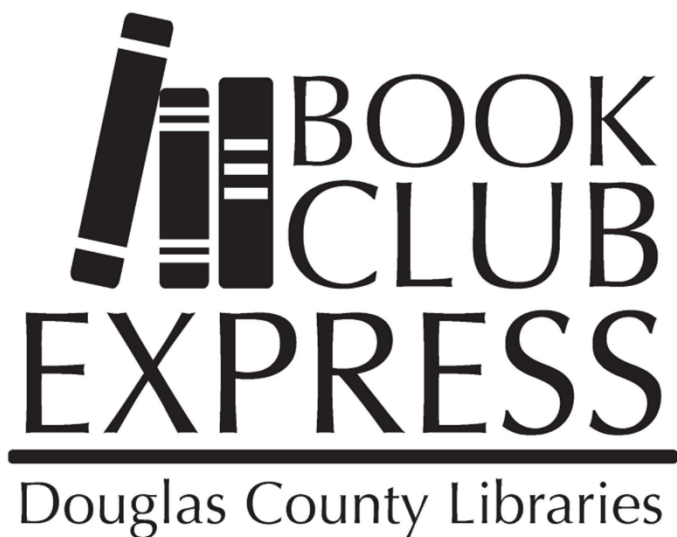




I See You've Called in Dead  
by John Kenney

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## Discussion Questions

1. Life and death are intrinsically connected throughout this novel, as Bud's confrontations with death are what drive him to begin to truly live. Do you believe this is an extreme position? Must we confront death so head-on in order to appreciate our lives?
2. In many ways, this novel is an ode to male friendship. Bud himself remarks on the difference between male and female friendship: "Women talked close, staring at each other, close, touched, hugged, said what they felt, said I love you out loud. We sat staring straight ahead, never touching, speaking more in the pauses, and yet still, if you listened closely, said I love you." (47) Did you find the depictions of male friendship throughout this novel different from depictions of female friendship you have read? If so, in what ways?
3. Bud uses humor to get through difficult conversations/times and sometimes as a method of deflection. This novel, as a whole, also deals with difficult topics using humor. Do you believe that using humor is an effective way to deal with difficulty?
4. Despite being incredibly critical of himself, Bud seems to be well-liked by many of the people around him. Did Bud's self perception make you question his trustworthiness as a narrator?
5. This book is, in part, about Bud's relationships and how they function during a difficult period of his life. Was there any particular friendship/relationship you found most moving?
6. "Rewriting your story" is a consistent theme throughout this book. Do you believe Bud successfully rewrites his story?
7. Clara asks Bud if he believes in God. When he doesn't respond, Clara lists different things in the world that make her either believe in God or make her think there is no God. What makes you believe? If not in God, then in humanity, fate, love, etc.
8. In the introduction to the novel, Bud poses the following question: "What would you write if you had to write your obituary? Today, right now. What comes to mind? What memories, days, moments? What people and experiences?" How would you answer this question?

## Author Interview

NPR's Scott Simon asks New Yorker contributor John Kenney about his comic new novel "I See You've Called in Dead." It's centered on a newswire obituary writer.

**SCOTT SIMON, HOST:** Bud Stanley writes obituaries for a living. He knows you are more likely to be killed by a cow than a shark, among many other important facts. One night, he has a disaster of a blind date, gets bad news from his ex-wife, goes home, has too much to drink and then writes too much.

**JOHN KENNEY:** (Reading) Bud Stanley, the first man to perform open heart surgery on himself, died today in a hot air balloon accident. He was 44. His wife, Miss France, has confirmed the death.

**SIMON:** At the wire service where he works the next day, the security guard tells him, I'm so sorry, Mr. Bud, but it appears you are maybe expired. Bud Stanley had written and posted his own obituary. "I See You've Called In Dead" is the new novel from John Kenney, the longtime New Yorker contributor. He joins us now from our studios in New York. Thanks so much for being with us.

**KENNEY:** Thank you for having me, Scott.

**SIMON:** Quite an inventive obit he writes for himself, isn't it?

**KENNEY:** It is. It's more wishful thinking than actual fact. It's one of those late-night things that he shouldn't have done.

**SIMON:** Is it, in addition to being maybe a product of too much to drink, a kind of electronic Freudian slip? Is that what he's really feeling about himself?

**KENNEY:** Yeah, I think that's fair to say. Bud is a guy who is lost but doesn't quite know it. As you said, he's two years into a divorce. His wife has left him. He's lost the spirit of his job, and he's not quite sure what to do. So he's sitting there making up these absolutely ridiculous things about his own life, kind of wondering what the point of it all is.

**SIMON:** He's fired, but then he can't be fired. What happens?

**KENNEY:** Well, they desperately want to fire him. But then, after a few days, they realize that he is dead to the company's enormous system, and they cannot legally fire a dead person.

**SIMON:** Since he can't quite stop living or working, Bud starts going to funerals of people who've - it makes you wonder, maybe he should have been going to them all the time before.

**KENNEY:** Yeah. The catalyst for that first wake he goes to is his ex-wife's mother passes away, and he was kind of close with her. And he goes, and that's a nightmare because he's seeing his ex-wife for the first time in two years. She's happily remarried to a far better-looking and more interesting man with an English accent. And...

**SIMON:** As she tells him, too, yeah.

**KENNEY:** Indeed. After the wake, he meets a young woman who is there for no other reason than she wanted to come to the wake and funeral of a stranger. And Bud is stunned by this and says, well, why? And she said, well, it's the secret. And he says, the secret to what? And she said, well, you have to find that out. And she suggests a funeral to him, and he goes, and he keeps going. That's really the essence. It's this journey, physical and emotional journey, that Bud is making with his good friend, Tim, to these wakes and funerals.

**SIMON:** And tell us about Tim. He's an especially vital character and - a lot going on in his life, doesn't he?

**KENNEY:** Yeah. So after Bud is divorced, he finds a small apartment in Brooklyn, and it's owned by this sort of - I don't know. It's a Gatsby-esque character, except he's a true Renaissance man. He's this remarkable guy. He was in a bad accident and is in a wheelchair. And yet his physical wound doesn't keep him from living and from, every few months, having a Gertrude Stein-esque salon in Brooklyn for sort of ne'er-do-wells, part-time poets and cellists. And Bud finds a community with Tim and relies on Tim in a way that he desperately needs.

You know, in a way, I think the bulk of this story is about male friendship. You know, my wife has many close friends. And the intimacy with which they talk, whether it's on the phone or in person, is so radically different than myself with my very small group of guy friends. You know, I'll say, you know, how are you doing? And they'll say, fine. What they really mean is, I'm doing terrible. I wake up at 3 a.m. crying. I lost my job, and I'm worried about money.

**SIMON:** What sparked your interest in obituaries?

**KENNEY:** I was a journalism major in college. And as part of the many different assignments we had, one of them was to write our own obituary. And I did not remotely take it seriously, which I know will come as a surprise to you, Scott.

**SIMON:** (Laughter).

**KENNEY:** And so it stuck with me. But I grew up in Boston, and my parents always read the Boston Globe obituaries. They called it the Irish sports page. I find them fascinating because there are these whole lives in 2-, 3-, 400 words. And when they're done well - and they often are - you know, it's a hard thing to do, to capture someone's life - the little nuances, not just where they went to school or their children's names. I find them really fascinating.

**SIMON:** I came across some words recently. Art Buchwald...

**KENNEY:** Great man.

**SIMON:** ...Ostensibly a humorist, like you?

**KENNEY:** Absolutely.

**SIMON:** Once said, the - I don't know what happens to us when we die. The question is, why are we here in the first place?

**KENNEY:** Yeah, and that's an individual question. And I know my answer, which is to try to be a decent friend and a great father and a semi-unannoying husband and to try to enjoy myself. You know, I did want to share - it's an intense subject, death, but the flip side of it is this valve release of humor, and I very much wanted that to be part of the book.

The catalyst for the book came in 2019. I'm one of five brothers, Boston Irish family. And one of my brothers passed away in 2019, Tom, and I dedicate the book to him. A really remarkable guy - like our father and grandfathers, he was a firefighter and just a big, handsome guy who loved life and loved his job. And he was on the Massachusetts FEMA team down at 9/11. And we think he contracted his illness, pancreatic cancer, during his time at 9/11.

But during those five months, we would visit, my brothers and I. I'd come up from the Boston area. And his wife called and said, you know, you really should get up. And I arrived first. And Tom was in a lounge chair with a blanket on him, far thinner than his normal self but still very much in there in that dark Irish humor. And we chatted, and I heard a car pull into the driveway. And I saw it was my other brothers, and I turned to Tom and I said, the others are here. And with this Buster Keaton-like stone face, but a little grin on his face, he dropped his head to one side and dropped his arm off the chair and, trying to hide a smile, said, tell them they're too late.

**SIMON:** (Laughter).

**KENNEY:** And I thought...

**SIMON:** Can I laugh?

**KENNEY:** Absolutely, because I did, too. And I thought, I want that in a book. I want to write a funnyish book about death because it gave me chills, too. In the face of the great unknown, he knew what was about to happen. He was able to find that dark, wonderful humor that makes life worth living.

**SIMON:** John Kenney - his new novel, "I See You've Called In Dead." Thanks so much for being with us.

**KENNEY:** Thank you, Scott.

<https://www.npr.org/2025/04/05/nx-s1-5287790/john-kenney-on-his-new-novel-i-see-youve-called-in-dead>

## Author Biography

John Kenney is the bestselling author of three novels and four books of poetry, including *I See You've Called in Dead*, *Talk to Me*, *Love Poems for Married People*, *Love Poems for People with Children*, and *Love Poems for Anxious People*. His first novel, *Truth In Advertising*, won the Thurber Prize for American Humor. He is a longtime contributor to *The New Yorker* magazine's *Shouts & Murmurs*. He lives in Larchmont, New York, with his wife, Lissa, a therapist, and two children, whose names currently escape him.

## Reviews

### I SEE YOU'VE CALLED IN DEAD by John Kenney

Professional obituary writer Bud Stanley is a divorcé coasting through life in Brooklyn. He discovered his wife was cheating on him when she accidentally sent him a text message meant for her lover. At work, he's uninspired, unable to muster the interest in writing about the recently deceased. After a particularly bad blind date, he drinks to excess and comes up with a bold, ill-advised idea. He writes and semi-accidentally publishes his own obituary and is summarily suspended from work, but not before his mentor suggests that he's unfit for his career: "You are an obituary writer who does not understand the first thing about life. Wake up," his boss pleads. It's from here that Kenney's touching, provocative novel takes off. During this time of suspension-induced depression and malaise, Bud relies heavily on his landlord, downstairs neighbor, and best friend, Tim Warren, who is paraplegic. While at a funeral for Bud's former mother-in-law, the duo meets Clara, a free spirit who quit her high-paying corporate job after missing her own father's death because of a meeting. Together, the three start going to funerals for people they don't know and have late-night discussions about life and death over wine. As Bud and Tim spend more time with Clara, each member of this unexpected triangle illuminates for the others the things that make life so rich. Bud comes to terms with his mother's death in a way he repressed for many, many years, while Tim begins to reveal how heavy of a toll his near-fatal accident and subsequent disability took on him. Through these death-related accoutrements—funerals, wakes, and obituaries—Bud begins to reckon with his purpose on this planet. Kenney doesn't propose any sort of clean answer, but alludes to the idea that life's richness comes from spending time with people you love, and that those relationships are built on mutual respect, truth, and love.

A touching ode to the people who make life worth living.

<https://www.kirkusreviews.com/book-reviews/john-kenney/i-see-youve-called-in-dead/>

## Read-Alikes

### The Road to Tender Hearts by Annie Hartnett

*The Road to Tender Hearts* follows PJ Halliday, a middle-aged man dealing with personal tragedy and emotional challenges. After a series of events, he unexpectedly becomes the guardian of his siblings' children, Ollie and Luna, who have lost their parents. Along with his adult daughter, Sophie, and their quirky cat, Pancakes, PJ embarks on a cross-country road trip to reconnect with an old love. The journey is both humorous and heartbreaking, filled with unique characters and deep themes such as trauma and the complexities of relationships. Hartnett's writing combines humor with a somber undertone, creating a captivating narrative that keeps readers engaged. Although the book explores dark subjects, it also showcases moments of hope and love. The characters are flawed, reflecting the realism of life, making their journey all the more relatable. Overall, this story is not just about adventure; it's a thoughtful examination of healing and connection amidst life's challenges.

### Grief Is for People by Sloane Crosley

*Grief is for People* is a memoir that delves into the author's experience of coping with multiple losses within a short span of time. The book explores the profound grief Crosley faces after losing her best friend, Russell, to suicide, juxtaposed with the theft of valuable family jewelry. Through her poignant writing style, Crosley navigates the complexities of friendship, loss, and the impact of grief, while also reflecting on the enduring importance of literature and storytelling. The narrative weaves together elements of humor, suspense, and introspection, offering a unique exploration of grief that is both moving and thought-provoking.

### The Collected Regrets of Clover by Mikki Brammer

*The Collected Regrets of Clover* follows the story of Clover, a 36-year-old death doula in New York, who has experienced loss at a young age and has built emotional armor around herself. Through her work, she collects the last words of her dying clients in notebooks labeled Regrets, Advice, and Confessions. As Clover navigates her own loneliness and fears, she forms meaningful friendships with an elderly neighbor and a new client's family, ultimately learning to open herself up to love and life. The novel delicately explores themes of grief, friendship, and the importance of living life to the fullest, even in the face of death. *The Collected Regrets of Clover* is beautifully written, touching on the topic of death with tenderness and shared humanity. The characters are multi-dimensional and realistic, with Clover's personal evolution as a death doula resonating deeply with readers. It offers profound insights into the preciousness of life, the significance of meaningful connections, and the transformative power of opening oneself up to vulnerability and love.

<https://www.meetnewbooks.com/suggest-book/1043176/I-See-You-ve-Called-in-Dead-John-Kenney/2>